

Voice Mails

Gone are the days when the answering machines and devices could only be connected to phone lines. With voice mail features that add power and flexibility to the simple answering machine, communication anytime, anywhere has become an easy task. Today's voice mail allows messages to be more detailed and lengthy and they can be accessed and acted upon by you even when you are on the road. In the future, this functionality will probably be

increased, for instance dialling the caller's number automatically. Some applications also permit creation of mailbox lists for sending the same voice message to different people. Several voice-messaging solutions today allow the conversion of recorded audio into the .WAV file format, which can then be delivered to an Internet location from where it can be accessed by people who may not have a voice mail system.



The Messageasap.com inbox for unified messaging



A unified mailbox and mobile access to your messages from Messageasap.com

Web-based UM services

There are several Internet-based services that are delivering UM capability to users. These services offer you access to e-mail, fax, voice mail and voice e-mail via a single inbox.

Your inbox can be accessed via a Web interface from any location. MessageASAP, one such service, allows you to install a client software that lets you store messages on your desktop itself. HotVoice.com is another service that adds instant messaging to the mix and has a client software that alerts you when you receive a new message.

However, to make use of all of the features on most of these services, you need to be a US-based consumer. For instance, people can leave voice messages for you on the US phone num-

ber that Onebox.com provides you with and you can access these any time from your universal inbox.

But, before you run out and create an account on one (or all) of these sites, you must take note of the fact that several of these free services, such as eTouch.com and MessageASAP.com, are turning into paid services.

Way to go

Although at present UM is not very popular with individuals, it has taken off well with corporates. The latter usually need to be able to send and receive e-mail, voice and fax messages at all times. Several of the companies that offer Web-based services to individuals, provide solutions to corporates too, for instance, uReach.com. But more excitingly, big boys such as Microsoft and Lotus have also entered the fray.

Microsoft's Exchange Server has been designed and developed to become a platform for unified messaging systems. It provides organisations of varying sizes with connectivity, a single physical store for messages of all media, and allows them to coexist with various protocols and clients.

It provides easy administration and most importantly, it integrates with Microsoft's Outlook software to deliver all of this to each individual user in a familiar environment. Lotus has a similar strategy with its Domino platform, which is already in use at a lot of organisations all over the world. Developers can now extend the functionality beyond the collaborative tools provided by Lotus Notes to unified messaging applications.

Other technology infrastructure companies such as Cisco, Dialogic and Ericson are developing technologies, products and solutions for unified messaging because of the potential for new services that integrated networks for data and voice will provide users.

Though initially these products are being developed for corporations, telecom service providers will eventually make the services available to individuals.

Some User Scenarios

1. Telephone access to e-mail

You can access and manage your e-mail and fax messages via a telephone. The system will notify you about waiting messages, read you the contents and allow you to reply to them with a recorded voice message. Longer messages can always be redirected to a nearby fax machine.

2. PC access to voice mail

Voice mail messages appear in the inbox, like regular e-mail and fax messages. You can play back the message through speakers or a headset. Forwarding or replying to messages is also possible.

3. Telephone access to information

You can access other applications and retrieve information such as current stock prices or financial performance data.

4. Wireless notification and access

If you are travelling, you can receive alerts about new e-mail via your mobile phone and then access and respond to them using a smart phone, a simple wireless device, or a PDA connected to your cell phone.

5. Fax mailboxes

Fax messages are delivered to an electronic mailbox, which allows you immediate access to them when you travel. Privacy is a major benefit, along with lower cost.

6. Web access to all messages

As all messages are in a single inbox, you can access them via a Web terminal.